



Patient education: Making healthy choices when eating out (The Basics)

Written by the doctors and editors at UpToDate

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Why is it important to eat a healthy diet?

Eating a healthy diet is important when you eat at home and when you eat out. Eating the right foods can keep you healthy now and later in life. It can lower the risk of problems like heart disease, diabetes, high blood pressure, obesity, and some types of cancer. It can also help you live longer and improve your quality of life.

Why is it harder to eat a healthy diet or limit calories when eating out?

Eating out can be a challenge for many reasons. Examples include:

- You have less knowledge of and control over the ingredients.
- Portion sizes tend to be bigger.
- It can be difficult to know the amount of fat, sodium, or calories in an item.

But you can eat out and still follow a healthy eating plan.

How can I avoid overeating when eating out?

If you are trying to eat fewer calories, here are some tips:

- Food portions at restaurants can be very big. Ask if you can order a half-size portion or a lunch option. Box up half of your meal before you start, or share a meal with someone.
- Avoid things like buffets, unlimited refills, baskets of bread, and all-you-can-eat options. These can all make it easier to overeat.
- Instead of ordering an appetizer, ask for your side salad or vegetable to be served before your other food.

- Eat a small, healthy snack before going out to eat so you are less hungry. This can help you choose healthier foods when you order.
 - Eat slowly and mindfully. This helps you notice when you start to feel full.
 - Drink water before and during the meal. This can help you feel fuller sooner.
 - Wait 15 to 30 minutes before ordering more food. This gives your body time to feel full and satisfied.
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How can I make healthier choices and limit calories when eating out?

Start by planning ahead. Many menus have information about the nutrition and calorie content of foods. Review this before you order take-out or go to a restaurant.

Some other tips:

- Choose dishes with more fruits and vegetables. Start with a salad, or choose 2 vegetables instead of a vegetable and a starch. Eating a salad or vegetables first can help you feel full sooner and give you important nutrients.
 - Order individual items instead of a full meal. This gives you more control over what you eat.
 - Ask how the food is cooked. Choose food that is baked, braised, grilled, broiled, steamed, or roasted instead of fried. Some foods can be cooked with less oil, butter, or added salt to make them healthier.
 - Ask for sauces, dressings, dips, and gravies to be served on the side. Choose a sauce made with tomatoes or other vegetables instead of a cream sauce. Use oil and vinegar instead of salad dressing.
 - When eating at fast food restaurants, look for healthier items, like broiled chicken.
 - Choose fruit, low-fat frozen yogurt, sorbet, or sherbet if you want dessert. You can also share a dessert with others.
 - Choose healthy fats like avocados, nuts, olive oil, or fatty fish.
 - Choose water or low-calorie beverages like unsweetened tea, seltzer with lemon or lime, or low-fat milk.
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What foods and drinks should I avoid when eating out?

Some things to avoid or limit when eating out:

- Limit unhealthy and saturated fat add-ons like cheese, bacon, mayonnaise, sour cream, or tartar sauce.
 - Avoid fried, battered, or breaded foods.
 - Avoid sauces made with cream or butter.
 - Avoid sodas, milkshakes, and drinks with alcohol.
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What else should I know?

- When you are going out to eat, think about your overall food plan for the day. Eat healthier, low-calorie foods for your other meals and snacks.
 - For special occasions, you can have a small amount of unhealthy foods, but limit how much.
 - Remember eating healthy is about the choices you make over time. You can still enjoy food, and eat out sometimes, while continuing to work toward your goals.
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